

[00:00:00.490] - Yazzie Min

Decolonisation was a word I hadn't even heard of, probably two or three years ago, maybe three years ago. And when I heard the word, I didn't even really know what it meant. Still, but it spoke to me, and I was like, yeah, there's something there, and this is a word that I haven't had access to, but I feel like it already explains a lot of things that I've been feeling, and sometimes we just need to name a thing. And it was one of those things for me.

[00:00:33.490] - Yazzie Min

But, in essence, it's understanding that the very fabric of our society is built on colonialism. And I feel like colonisation in itself, is really referred to as a thing of the past, a past that we don't really condemn either. It's kind of a glorified past, but it's definitely not present, even the way we refer to it, or the world has a term of, like "the colonial times", like it was an era and a natural fact. We're still living in those same structures today, and colonisation has taken on, and it's evolved basically into a different form that perhaps doesn't look like what it might have done a few centuries ago, but is very much still present.

[00:01:33.450] - Yazzie Min

And it's a more invisible kind of structure that - if you are somebody who benefits from it without, and just remember without intent - it's not conscious. But colonisation was set up with something that was born out of white supremacy to benefit those with white skin privilege (is what the term needs to be called). And it's called white privilege now, but it's basically white skin privilege. And so when a white person, for example, might not even know it's happening and know what's going on because it's very much an experience of lacking something.

[00:02:17.490] - Yazzie Min

So, if you're experiencing white privilege, it's very hard to explain white privilege to somebody because you're actually trying to explain something that isn't there - a lack of something. Things that you don't experience are the things that give you privilege. And being a marginalised individual - as a black or brown person - there could be a number of things that happen in our morning, even before we leave the house that we might have to think about, that a white person doesn't have to. But trying to explain that - that invisible thing -

[00:02:54.930] - Yazzie Min

(and this is what I mean when I say colonisation has evolved) trying to explain that when it's not something that is experienced. But you're saying to me you have privilege and that the person who doesn't know that they have privilege is being told to understand something invisible. This is where the understandable confusion lies. And also, where I stand, I can see colonisation still at play here, over the top of it all. It's having a parade and a field day in that separation, in the misunderstanding, in the double messages, in everything feeling very subjective to black or brown people. White people can't say anything anymore without putting their foot in it.

[00:03:40.530] - Yazzie Min

All of those things are still white supremacy at play, whether we're conscious of it or not. And so to decolonise is to really take down and dismantle a system that doesn't serve the whole. But there are other ways you can hold privilege, not just white skin privilege, for example, male privilege, cisgendered privilege, heteronormative privilege, able-bodied privilege. I hold privilege in many ways. But, to decolonise, it is about reimagining a whole different way of being that includes the whole, looks after the whole, has us all as equal, as opposed to a hierarchy that currently exists.

[00:04:43.770] - Chris Johnstone

There has been historical periods where some groups - particularly Europe-origin white skin groups - basically did a land grab and a power grab that was putting themselves in a position of ascendancy over others. And it's a bit like if there were just so many families and one family basically took over so much and generations later - through inheritance and things like that - that family still had the controlling rights to things and other people, some of them had degrees of privilege that had risen and fallen. But the idea that it's somehow a kind of a level playing field is just completely untrue because there are inherited positions of privilege, access to resources and privilege, capacities and

rights, which I guess, if you've always had water, you don't know what it's like to be thirsty.

[00:05:55.890] - Chris Johnstone

And if one family, or group of families, had basically taken over access to fresh water and made sure that they never had to feel thirst... But other groups had lacked access or limited access to water and spent degrees of time feeling thirsty, the people who'd always had adequate water wouldn't know what it's like to feel thirsty. I don't know. I'm just jumping at different metaphors here.

[00:06:25.290] - Yazzie Min

Yes, that is it. And also the people that are thirsty know that they are thirsty because of those that have never known what it's like to be thirsty. Not blaming those people who won't know that that's the reason why. But understanding that it's a structural thing, a systemic thing that has led for it to be that way. And the people that have access to water are unaware that that is a systemic thing and not just something that they worked hard for, for example, because if trying to drag the water analogy along, say, for example, it comes out of the tap for those people, whereas those that don't have access to it have to go and walk to the well every day.

[00:07:22.570] - Yazzie Min

And they are working extra hard to get the same thing.

[00:07:29.590] - Chris Johnstone

And there's something here about Active Hope really,

[00:07:34.090] - Chris Johnstone

You're saying: okay, what do we hope for here? And how can we be active in that? So I'm interested in this term "anti-oppressive practice". And I wonder if you could say a bit more about what that is and how we do it?

[00:07:48.910] - Yazzie Min

Well, really, going back to what you said about the solidarity...

[00:07:52.090] - Yazzie Min

It's solidarity and empathy with others, and really making a connection, and taking it as a priority to do that work in ourselves. So if there's any kind of reference to an anti-oppressive practice, it's taking that responsibility for yourself and: 1) checking where your privilege is - to know and be aware - that it's not something that anybody is angry at you for having, you know, it's a lottery. We're just born as we are. And however we fall into what societal structures are already created. It's a lottery at birth. So there's no blame or shame or guilt needed around knowing what your privileges are.

[00:08:45.550] - Yazzie Min

But it is important that you do know what they are. So you can then use those to level the playing field. That's always what it's about. So acknowledging what your privileges are and doing the research and knowing that I really need to understand how I uphold privilege because this doesn't resonate with me. I don't feel that I'm privileged in any way, and I think the word privilege causes a lot of resistance because it automatically... I remember when I first heard the word privilege. I felt like it was to do with money and wealth.

[00:09:25.090] - Yazzie Min

And those are things that it definitely could be to do with... But even if you were somebody that is privileged and has money and wealth, it might be, well, I've worked really hard for that. And that's something that - I didn't just get that handed to me on a silver spoon. And that's not what the word, it's not what it means. It's actually that you've been born into a system that you had no control over and the things that you're afforded from having to live with due to X, Y and Z of your demographic, and knowing that that's not your experience, or my experience, or anyone's experience is different to anyone else's, because of those things.

[00:10:09.290] - Yazzie Min

And if we stay silent on those or just think, well, luck of the draw. I'll just make do with what I've got. And it's not my fault that I was born X, Y and Z and really removing that kind of blame notion of it and recognising it as a basic human duty for us all to put a system right, really dismantle the system and build a new one. But we can't do that before we know what we're working with. We have to know how we uphold power, even subconsciously, and then using our privileges and our power to create a more equal world.

[00:10:57.470] - Chris Johnstone

So can you just walk me through how I might do that, for example, if you were to be my coach, my anti-oppressive practice coach, how might you guide me to kind of say, okay, I think of the Great Turning, and the first part is just turning up. So I'm turning up with willingness here, recognising that there's - as well as the great turning, there's the wrong turning - we've taken the wrong turning in all kinds of ways. And so turning up with willingness to move in a better direction. There are certain things I'm going to be moving away from - turning away from - and certain things I'm going to be turning towards...

[00:11:42.450] - Chris Johnstone

How might you facilitate me in terms of developing more anti-oppressive expression and being.

[00:11:54.030] - Yazzie Min

The starting point might be just to list out areas that you hold privilege in, and there might be areas you haven't even thought about. And that's okay. You're bringing yourself to the awareness stage first. That's where it has to start. Typically, a middle class, able-bodied, straight, cisgendered white male, if you like, would be at the top of the hierarchy of holding power. And so - as somebody holding that - if I was you, I would be like, right, I'm not even aware that these things.. Or perhaps you are? Depending on... There are certain things that you might already be aware of.

[00:12:39.990] - Chris Johnstone

But then there definitely will be areas for all of us that we're not aware of, because they're not things we've had to think about. For me, for example, I turn up in the world as a brown woman, which I've been made to be aware of from a very young age, sure. And as a woman, sure, there are definitely things that I've understood from again, an early age - that you're going to have to figure out a different way to get heard in that room, or seen in that place, or understood by that person, for example.

[00:13:13.170] - Yazzie Min

And I know it's a woman thing. However, I'm a straight woman, and I'm a cisgendered woman. I've had the incredible privilege of being born into the world, feeling connected to the identity that I had at birth, the biological identity. So not thinking about how a trans person might turn up in the world or experience the world, or even that certain things have been illegal, not thinking about bathroom choices, just walking straight into the ladies and not giving that a second thought. That's a privilege that I wouldn't have thought about maybe five years ago.

[00:13:55.950] - Yazzie Min

And ultimately, people will only just be coming to that realisation themselves. And so really taking the time to see this as a priority, I think, and knowing that this lies with all of us, and if all of us do our bit to acknowledge where we uphold power and how we can move through those things to not subconsciously cause harm to others. For example, with systemic racism, the way the system is backed up by our daily interactions, microaggressions - things that come out that it's very hard to describe - things that come out that might feel subconscious or actually that might well be subconscious...

[00:14:55.070] - Yazzie Min

But to a black or brown person, they don't feel subconscious, they feel like, you know what you're doing. And you know, there's no way I can prove that this would be considered racism. It's always something that's got a thin veil of something else over the top of it, or a backhanded compliment but it's something to kind of just let you know your place. So, for example, wow, you speak really good English for a brown person. Wow. Your family is from India, right? Yeah. But I was born and raised

here, even if I wasn't, it's a little bit cringe worthy to compliment me on my English for a brown person!

[00:15:35.750] - Yazzie Min

But they're just gentle ways or subtle ways that keep reminding you of your otherness, so to speak. And there are things that - because they're just so part and parcel of our society - whether they're jokes, whether they are sly comments, whether they're just things that you've repeated without even realising those things carry so much harm in them. And, of course, if you're not on the receiving end of that, you don't know what it feels like because it just seems like a harmless joke. If you look at some of the things that James Baldwin said as a gay black man in America in the 60s, Audre Lorde as a gay black woman in the 60s, the things that they're speaking feel so relevant and so ahead of their time.

[00:16:27.530] - Yazzie Min

And it's not that they necessarily are. It's that, again, those levels of progression were kept stunted because it's not in the interest of these systems to have equality. And so it's really, as a people now, we've never had a global awakening on this level before, ever, when it comes to race, it's now in our power. And it's exciting that we have that. And so we all just doing our bit to educate ourselves and then lean into that empathy that we talked about, because leaning into that empathy means that we also have to challenge our egos.

[00:17:12.750] - Yazzie Min

And I always say that race work is ego work. It will flare up really uncomfortable, not very nice parts of ourselves. And they're the things we have to face and sit with and work through in order to be able to act and dismantle and rebuild.